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Education bills signed by governor promote literacy, nutrition, safety

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Gov. Gavin Newsom has signed several bills that will affect schools, including one that boosts literacy programs and another that eases admission to California State University.

The governor continued to work his way Friday through bills passed by the Legislature, as the Monday deadline looms for legislation to be signed. The education bills include efforts to improve youngsters' diets and to protect students from anti-semitism and serial sex abusers.

The bills signed into law by Newsom include:

AB 715

Establishes a new Office of Civil Rights along with an Antisemitism Prevention Coordinator to develop training, resources and enforcement strategies for K–12 schools. The legislation, from Assemblymembers Rick Chavez Zbur (D-Hollywood) and Dawn Addis (D-Morro Bay) also requires districts to investigate and take action when content that is deemed discriminatory is used in classrooms or professional development. The governor signed the bill Tuesday, along with a companion bill that passed the state Senate (see below).

AB 1264

Identifies ingredients found in ultraprocessed foods, while seeking to eliminate the items from school meals over the next 10 years. The ingredients include artificial flavors and colors, thickeners and emulsifiers, certain sweeteners, along with any foods that have high levels of saturated fat, sodium or sugar. The bill, by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino), was signed Wednesday.

AB 1454

The bill, from Assembly Speaker Robert Rivas (D-Salinas), offers educators and school leaders access to tools, training and resources to help students become better readers. Elementary school teachers now will received training in evidence-based reading instruction, or the science of reading. The State Board of Education also must embrace compatible instructional materials for use in elementary and middle schools. The effort follows Newsom's commitment of $480 million in the 2025-26 budget for literacy programs.

SB 48

Complements AB 715 by creating four statewide Discrimination Prevention Coordinators — focused on religious, racial, ethnic, gender and LGBTQ discrimination — to provide resources and training to prevent and address bias and discrimination in schools. State Sen. Akilah Weber Pierson (D-San Diego) shared authorship of the bill with three colleagues, including Assemblymember Chris Ward, also a San Diego Democrat.

SB 640

Allows for direct-admission policies for students whose eligible to attend a CSU campus. If their grades and coursework qualify them for CSU admission, they will receive a letter signed by the chancellor telling them they've been accepted at a list of campuses with enrollment capacity. The governor signed the bill, from state Sen. Christopher Cabaldon (D-West Sacramento) on Monday.

SB 848

The law requires the creation of a database to track teachers under investigation for sexual abuse and training for teachers, coaches and other school staff on how to prevent and report suspected misconduct. Schools also must create policies that outline what constitutes appropriate behavior. State Sen. Sasha Renée Pérez (D-Pasadena) announced the bill's signing in a Tuesday news release.

CalMatters, a nonpartisan and nonprofit news organization, and EdSource contributed to this report.

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